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Product Review: Windows 2000

Why you might want to stay away from Win2K

By Mike Talon



Unless you've been hiding under a rock for the last few months, you've no doubt seen the ads for Windows 2000, Microsoft's latest operating system designed to replace Windows NT in your office. However, even though they seem to be advertising it to everyone with eyeballs, this latest Windows family program isn't for everyone.

What is Windows 2000?

Windows 2000 is the latest in the Windows line of computer operating systems—the software that runs your computer and all the other programs you want to run. This latest version combines the best elements of Windows 98 with the best elements of the Windows NT line of software.

This means you get plug-and-play hardware installation, a great user interface and the familiarity of Windows 98, combined with the enhanced networking and stability of Windows NT. You will also find new network management tools, like Active Directory, which are not found in either of its predecessors.

Windows 2000 also sports a new enhanced user interface. Features like fading menus, which give positive feedback to users, and easier-to-find utilities will make this version of Windows much more pleasant to use. In addition, the ability to use dial-up connections and networking hookups have been greatly overhauled and are now fully integrated into Windows. This makes getting onto the Internet an almost seamless process, whether you use a phone connection or are attached to a network.

Who it's for

Windows 2000 is ideal for the corporate workplace. It comes in three flavors: two server versions for running network computers, and the "Professional" version, which is meant for the end user desktop or laptop. Corporate network administrators will find the enhancements to security, reliability and usability to be a true plus, requiring less administration and allowing more of the necessary administration to be done remotely. In addition, the new enhancements make laptop installation a snap—something that was sorely lacking in Windows NT.

Who it is not for

Home users will find that the design of Windows 2000 is nice, but it won't run a great deal of the entertainment software that's out there. Games and other graphics-intensive programs will run, but with much

less success than on Windows 98. This is due to the fact that the Windows NT core (on which Win 2000 is built) doesn't effectively handle 3D graphics and full-motion animation. There is also only limited support for entertainment technology like DVD video (though DVD data disks work just fine).

The bottom line
Although the final release of Windows 2000 is stable, like all new operating systems there are still bugs to be worked out. Corporate users should grab an upgrade copy to start working on integration now, as the full version will be ready for wide release within six months.

Home users should hold off and wait for Windows ME (Millennium Edition), which is reported to have the same stability and enhancements as Windows 2000, but will allow for better multimedia and gaming performance. The first Windows 2000 service pack should be your indication that the system is ready for network-wide installation; as for Windows ME, Microsoft plans to release the new home version within six months.

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